The search for talent has gone beyond B-schools at the diversified Aditya Birla Group as well. Ramachandran speaks of hiring from over 60 campuses spanning multiple courses. "That includes design, fashion, law, engineering, analytics and data science campuses. We also hire specifically for sectors such as e-commerce, hospitality and jewellery," he points out.

To most people, an MBA in the era of AI needs to be viewed differently, but Ramachandran believes it is not a choice between the two.

"AI is a powerful enabler but leadership still requires the ability to ask the right questions, identify which problems matter, derive meaningful insights and make decisions with accountability," he says. An MBA, to his mind, continues to provide a strong foundation in business understanding, structured problem-solving and decision-making.

"However, we look beyond degrees and evaluate candidates for the cognitive, behavioural and leadership capabilities required to succeed in our organisation," adds Ramachandran.

Anupam Kaura, Chief Human Resources Officer at Kotak Mahindra Bank, does not view technology talent and management talent as competing priorities but complementary capabilities. "AI can process information, automate workflows and generate insights at scale. But organisations still need people who can define the right problems, understand customer contexts, make judgement calls and translate insights into business outcomes," he says.

At this point, all stakeholders in the MBA ecosystem—students, B-schools and recruiters—are trying to put their best foot forward. It is really a case of doing the little things well and being flexible through this challenging journey.

"A slice of management or a full-fledged MBA always helps," says M.P. Gupta, Director of IIM Lucknow.

"In the world of AI, where automated shopfloors and connected factories are par for the course, a general management degree may be limited in terms of scope. A strong appreciation of technology is necessary in line with what industry needs," he says.

In recent times, India's top B-schools have also started offering undergraduate programmes. This year, IIM Lucknow welcomed its first batch of the four-year BS (Bachelor of Science) in AI and Business Analytics.

"AI is about management technology and business technology. We need to offer a high-quality programme to cover computer vision, cyber security, real-time business stimulation, and language processing, among other things," says Gupta.

By all counts, it is an indication of the direction management education is taking in India.

It may not be a replica of how it is playing out in other parts of the world, but the change is evident. And as always, in a very unique Indian way. BT

@krishnagopalan



"We increasingly need fungible talent: people who can move across contexts and translate strategy into outcomes"

ASHOK RAMACHANDRAN
DIRECTOR (HR),
ADITYA BIRLA GROUP



"There is no single pathway, be it an MBA or technology background, to develop capabilities"

HARSH CHHAPRIA
SENIOR PARTNER,
MCKINSEY & COMPANY